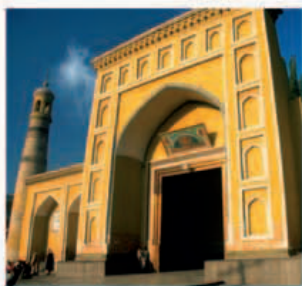


The **Id Kah Mosque**, in Kashgar, was built in 1422, but includes older structures dating back to the 8th century, and began as a mosque in 996. Kashgar is situated at the meeting point of the northern and southern Silk Roads, and was the gateway to the West. Set up as a garrison town at the foot of the Pamirs by 76 CE, it gave access to the mountain passes into Central Asia, India, and Persia.



The **Taklimakan desert** was a major obstacle between China and lands to the west. The Silk Road split into two routes that skirted the desert—one to the north and one to the south.

Built in the 1st century BCE as a garrison town, Gaochang became an important religious center, where Buddhism was firmly established.

A vital oasis near the junction of the northern and southern branches of the Silk Road, Dunhuang flourished under both the Han and Tang. A hoard of fascinating documents, collected over the centuries by Dunhuang's Buddhist monks, was discovered in a cave in 1900.

The Silk Road under the Mongols

Although the Mongols under Kublai Khan did not complete their conquest of China until 1279, they had already won control of the north by the death of Genghis Khan in 1227. Northern China, together with conquests in Central Asia, Persia, and Russia formed a continuous swath of Mongol territories, all linked by the traditional routes of the ancient Silk Road.

The geometrical center of China, the city of Lanzhou on the Yellow River was a major trading hub for the Silk Road under the Han dynasty.

A former capital of China, Chang'an (modern-day Xi'an) marked the start of the Silk Road from the east. From here, trade also traveled east, to Korea and Japan.

VENETIAN MERCHANT AND ADVENTURER (1254–1324)

MARCO POLO

As a teenager, Venetian Marco Polo accompanied his father and uncle on their second expedition to China, where they reached the fabled court of Kublai Khan. Marco learned the Mongol language and the Great Khan employed him as roving envoy and governor for three years in eastern China. He returned to Venice in 1295, but the following year was captured in a naval battle against the Genoese. In captivity, he dictated an account of his travels to a fellow inmate. Marco Polo's *Travels* was the most detailed account of East Asia available to European readers. It was printed in 1483 and influenced the thinking of many later would-be explorers.

“I have not told half of what I saw”

MARCO POLO, 1324



AFTER

A number of factors contributed to the decline of the Silk Road, which did not survive into the 15th century.

THE BLACK DEATH

Outbreaks of bubonic plague started in China in the 1330s, and the Silk Road was probably the principal means of transmission of the **Black Death 186–87** >> across Central Asia to Europe.

COLLAPSE OF MONGOL CHINA

Having secured the route since the mid-13th century, the Mongols lost control of China to the **Ming dynasty** << 166–67 in 1368.

TRADE UNDER THE MING

In the early 15th century, the Chinese joined Arab, Persian, and Indian merchants trading in the Indian Ocean. The **treasure fleets** commanded by **Zheng He** << 167 shipped goods such as blue-and-white porcelain to the Middle East and even to Africa.

NEW ROUTE

Trade between Europe and East Asia became possible via the **sea route to India 224–25** >> pioneered by Vasco de Gama in 1498.

ARCHAEOLOGY

The Silk Road was **rediscovered** by European explorers in the 19th century. It was given its name by a German geographer, Ferdinand Von Richthofen. A number of **ancient cities** in the Taklimakan region were excavated, including Dunhuang and Gaochang.



GAOCHANG

A NEW SILK ROAD

In 1998, representatives from more than 30 countries met to discuss the possibility of developing a modern **Europe–Caucasus–Asia** equivalent of the ancient routes.